

Andrea Salvanti

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EDUCATION	Universitat Pompeu Fabra, <i>Ph.D. Candidate in Economics</i> 2022 Present	
	Advisor: Prof. Antonio Penta	
	Universitat Pompeu Fabra, <i>MRes in Economics</i>	2021 2022
	Barcelona School of Economics, <i>M.Sc. in Economics</i>	2020 2021
	University of Bologna, <i>M.Sc. in Economics</i> (summa cum laude) (Thesis Advisor: Maria Bigoni)	2018 2020
	University of Trento, <i>B.Sc. in Economics</i> (summa cum laude)	2015 2018
REFERENCES	Professor Antonio Penta (advisor) BSE, ICREA, TSE, UPF (+34) 935 422 551 antonio.penta@upf.edu	Professor Larbi Alaoui BSE, UPF (+34) 935 422 842 larbi.alaoui@upf.edu
	Professor Jose Apesteguia BSE, ICREA, UPF (+34) 935 422 521 jose.apesteguia@upf.edu	Professor Maria Bigoni University of Bologna (+39) 051 209 2676 maria.bigoni@unibo.it
TEACHING POSITIONS (BSE)	Advanced Microeconomics II (General Equilibrium and Game Theory), first year course of the Ph.D. for Professor Antonio Penta – Spring 2023 and Spring 2024	
	Econometrics, first year course of the Ph.D. for Professor Christian Brownlees – Spring 2022	
	Crash Courses in Math, first year course of the Ph.D. for Professor Alexander Frug – Fall 2022 and Fall 2023	
RESEARCH POSITIONS	Research Assistant for professor Antonio Penta, 2021-2022	
	Research Intern in Bank of Italy, 2021-2023	
	Research Assistant for professor Maria Bigoni, 2019-2020	
JOB MARKET PAPER	Extracting Models from Data: A Cost-Benefit Framework with Patrick Sewell (UPF and BSE)	
	<i>Abstract.</i> We develop a theoretical framework for analyzing how decision makers form theories and extract behavioral rules directly from data. We distinguish a stable data-generating process (DGP) linking a relevant set of variables to outcomes from dataset-specific correlations that can make rules based on irrelevant variables perform well in some datasets but not in others. Rule extraction reflects a cost–benefit trade-off between a rule’s value and the cognitive cost of processing it. The framework predicts when agents extract the optimal behavioral rule that generalizes across datasets, how they substitute toward alternatives, when irrelevant variables lower its extraction, and how differences in cognitive costs generate systematic heterogeneity in rule extraction among agents learning from the same data. We test these predictions in our experiment and in the data of Kendall and Oprea (2024), and find strong support for them in both settings. We also show how rule-specific costs can be identified from observed choices and use the framework to determine which observable measures of complexity can be interpreted as entering the cost function.	

SUBMITTED PAPERS

The Importance of Being Even: Restitution and Cooperation

R&R at AEJ: Microeconomics

with Maria Bigoni (University of Bologna), Marco Casari (University of Bologna), Andrzej Skrzypacz (Stanford University), and Giancarlo Spagnolo (Roma Tor Vergata)

Abstract. We study—empirically and theoretically—how restitution helps restore cooperation after a breach or an exploratory defection. Restitution strategies propose a return to cooperation by cooperating against defection, and condition actions on the balance between cooperation given and received. We reanalyze experimental data from repeated Prisoner's Dilemma games and find empirical support for restitution strategies in general, and for a strategy we name Payback, in particular. Besides explaining how subjects deal with conflicts, accounting for restitution strategies helps reconcile discrepancies between theory and experiments—such as the widespread use of non-equilibrium strategies like Tit-for-Tat and the limited predictive power of risk dominance under imperfect monitoring.

WORKING PAPERS

Choice by Contextual Associations

with Jose Apesteguia (UPF and BSE)

Abstract. Choice behavior is significantly influenced by context. Evidence from cognitive science suggests that this dependency may be driven by associations. In this paper, we propose a choice-theoretic model of contextual associations. We formalize contexts as sets of topics. This allows us to define associations as links between alternatives and topics that directly impact utility. We characterize the model's empirical content, establish conditions for identification, analyze its comparative statics, and propose several extensions. To demonstrate the model's portability, we apply it to a probabilistic voting setting providing a new mechanism based on contextual associations explaining political polarization.

Strategic Risk in Repeated Games with Imperfect Monitoring

Abstract. In this paper I study the trade-off between efficiency and strategic risk in the context of a repeated Prisoner's Dilemma with imperfect public monitoring. Because unfavorable public signals and resulting punishments can occur on the equilibrium path, keeping the value of cooperation high requires players to adopt more lenient and forgiving strategies, which leaves them more exposed to opportunistic behavior. For a broad class of one-dimensional public signals, I show that under imperfect monitoring, strategy adoption responds to beliefs about the opponent's strategy, whereas under perfect monitoring, beliefs affect only the extensive margin—that is, the decision of whether to cooperate at all. Finally, I use experimental data from Aoyagi and Fréchette (2009) to document suggestive patterns consistent with subjects choosing strategies to maximize the cooperation value rather than controlling for strategic risk.

ONGOING WORK

The Fundamental Attribution Error in Hiring Decisions

with Eva Spantidaki Kyriazi (University of Vienna)

Abstract. We develop a theoretical framework to study the fundamental attribution error in hiring: the tendency to over-attribute observed performance to worker ability and under-attribute it to circumstances. In our framework, employers learn how observed performance maps into underlying ability and circumstances directly from data, rather than updating pre-existing knowledge withing a given mental model. This allows us to link the emergence and magnitude of attribution errors to measurable features of the environment, including the statistical properties of the data and the relative predictive power of ability and task difficulty. Heterogeneity in individuals' costs of processing information further generates systematic differences in the extent of the bias. We therefore move beyond treating the fundamental attribution error as a fixed predisposition by linking it to objective features of the environment, thereby identifying potential margins for policy intervention. We test these predictions in a laboratory hiring experiment.

Learning with Endogenous Data

Self-Projection and Sorting Across Environments

RESEARCH GRANTS

REACT Grant (4,980 €), *Universitat Pompeu Fabra*

2026

HONORS and AWARDS

FPI Scholarship, *Spanish Government*

2022-2026

Scholarship "G. Mortara", *Bank of Italy*

2021

Best Thesis Award, *BSE*

2020

The Thesis was published in the BSE repository.	
Grant for Excellence in studies , <i>University of Bologna</i>	2020
Graduate with Distinction , <i>University of Bologna</i>	2020
Grant for Excellence in studies , <i>University of Trento</i>	2018
Graduate with Distinction , <i>University of Trento</i>	2018

SEMINARS – CONFERENCES

Presentations

- ESA meeting, Barcelona, September 2026
- Econometric Society meeting, Dublin, August 2026
- FUR, Alicante, June 2026
- HEC PhD workshop, Paris, June 2026
- EAYE annual meeting, Bilbao, May 2026
- ASFEE conference, Nancy, June 2025
- Summer School in Experimental and Behavioral Economics (EER), Crete, August 2024
- BSE Summer Forum, Barcelona, June 2023
- EAYE annual meeting, Turin, September 2023

Attendance

- European Symposium of Economic Theory (ESSET), Gerzensee, July 2026
- BSE Summer Forum, Barcelona, June 2022/2023/2024/2025/2026
- ESA meeting, Bologna, September 2022

REFEREING ACTIVITIES

Review of Economic Studies; Experimental Economics; European Economic Review; Economia Politica

ADDITIONAL INFORMATION

Programming Languages: Python, Stata, Wolfram Mathematica, Matlab, R, Latex
Languages Spoken: English (Fluent), Italian (Native), Spanish (Fluent), Greek (Beginner)